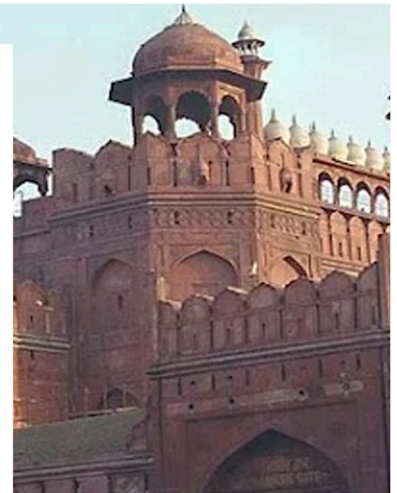
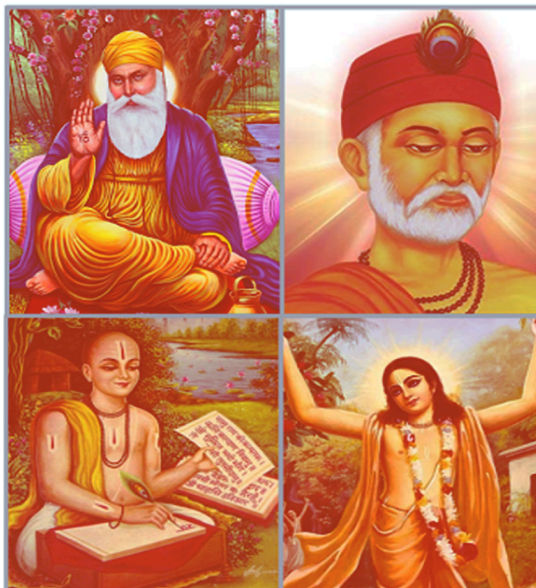
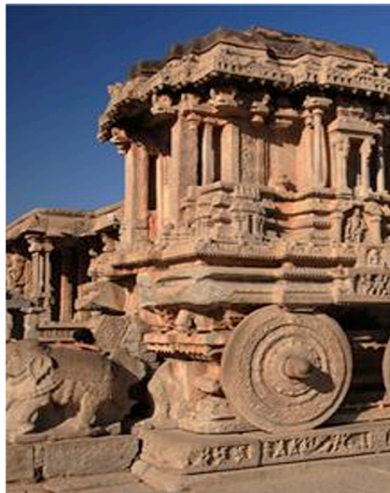


General Knowledge

Medieval History

STUDY NOTES

The Vijayanagar Empire



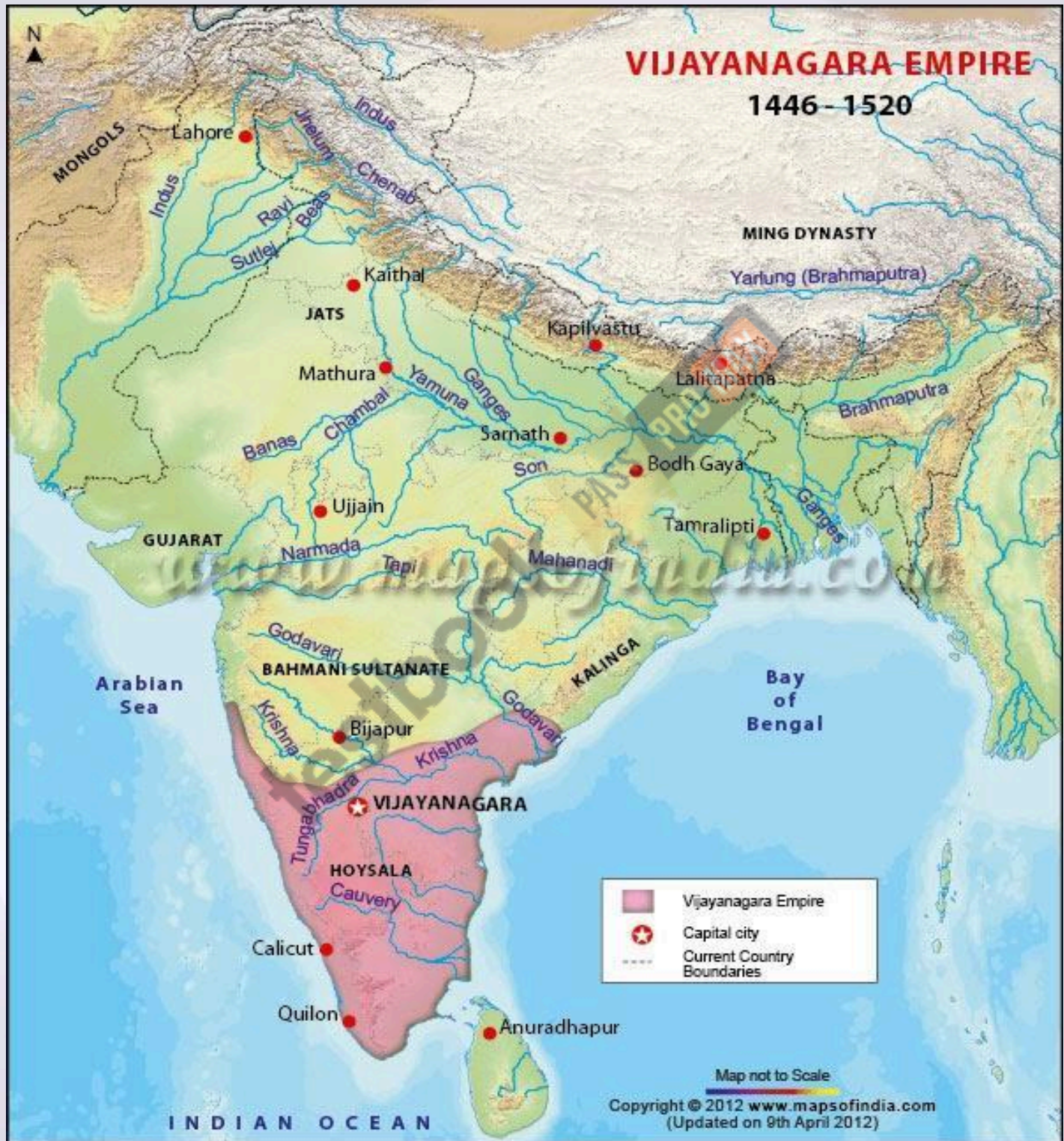
● Overview of the Empire

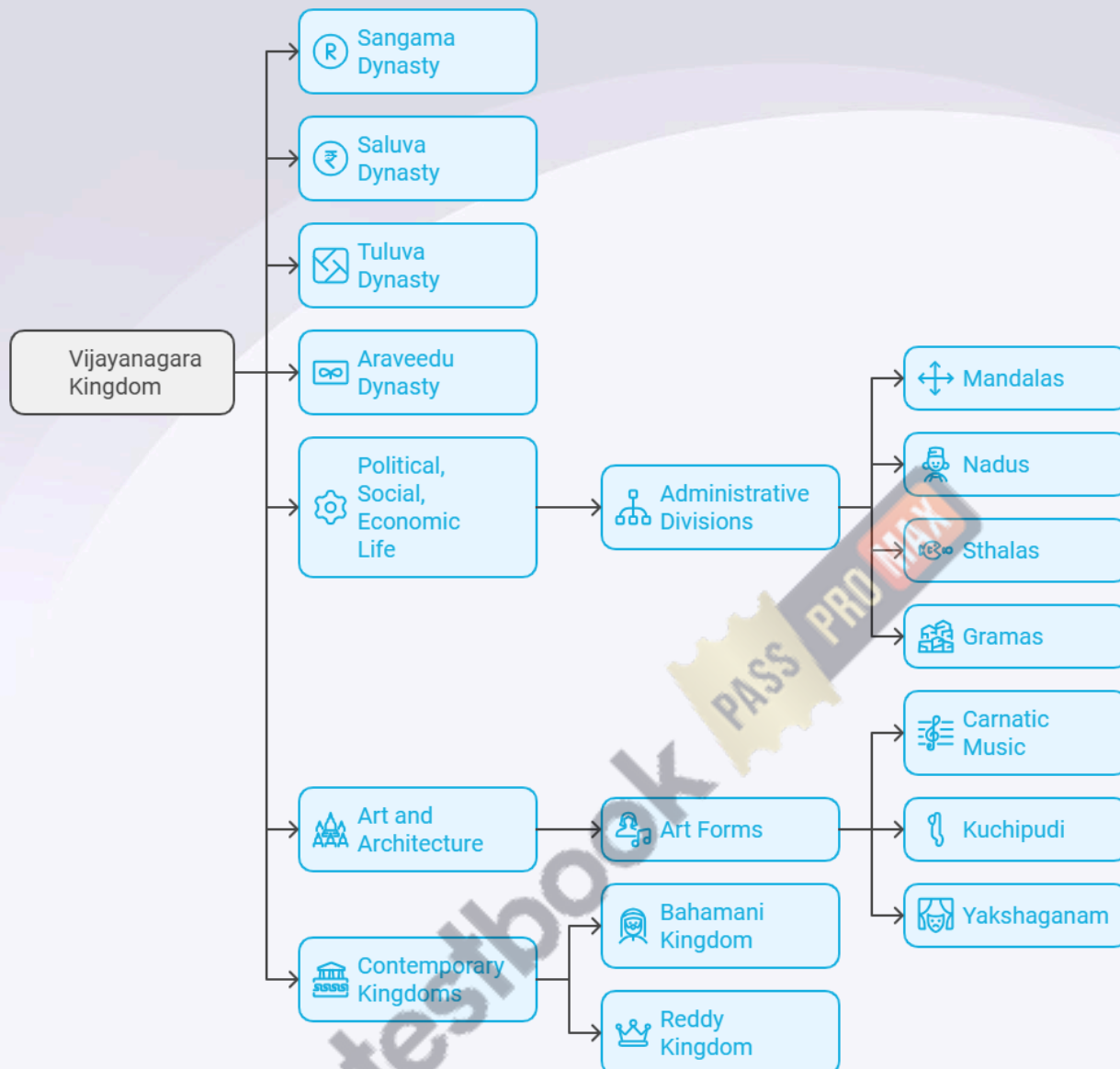
- Vijayanagara or “city of victory” was the name of both a city and an empire.
- The empire was founded in the fourteenth century



- It stretched from the river Krishna in the north to the extreme south of the peninsula.
- The city of Vijayanagara was sacked in 1565, leading to its abandonment and decline.
- The site of the former capital is known as Hampi, named after the local goddess Pampadevi.
- Vijayanagara Empire was founded by Harhar 1 and Bukkaraya 1.
- It was found in 1336 in the region of Deccan.
- It was also known as the Karnataka kingdom.
- The foundation of the Vijayanagara state towards the middle of the 14th century is generally attributed to a group of five brothers, namely, Bukka, Harihara, Kampana, Mudappa, and Marappa.
- The founding figures of the kingdom are also known as the Sangamas, after their father's name.
- Saint Vidyanarya helped the five brothers to establish the empire sometime in 1336 A.D.
- At first, the young kingdom had to contend both with the Hoysala ruler of Mysore and the Sultan of Madurai.

- By 1346, the whole kingdom of Hoysala passed into the hands of the Vijayanagara rulers





● Rulers of Vijayanagar

The empire was ruled by several dynasties over the years:



- **Sangama Dynasty (1336-1485 CE):**

- **Hari Har I**

- Founded the Vijayanagara Empire, with its first ruler being Harihara I and Bukka Raya I.
- They expanded the empire and established Hampi as the capital.
- This period saw significant developments in administration, architecture, and culture.



Sangam Dynasty Year Wise Rulers

Harihara I	1336–1356
Bukka Raya I	1356–1377
Harihara Raya II	1377–1404
Virupaksha Raya	1404–1405
Bukka Raya II	1405–1406
Deva Raya I	1406–1422
Ramachandra Raya	1422
Vira Vijaya Bukka Raya	1422–1424
Deva Raya II	1424–1446
Mallikarjuna Raya	1446–1465
Virupaksha Raya II	1465–1485
Praudha Raya	1485

- **Saluva Dynasty (1485-1505 CE):**
 - The Saluva dynasty was the second dynasty to rule the Vijayanagara Empire

- This dynasty marked a brief period of instability but also saw important rulers like Narasimha Saluva.
- They contributed to military expansion and consolidation of power.

Saluva Narasimha Deva Raya	1485-1491
Thimma Bhupala	1491
Narasimha Raya II	1491-1505

● **Tuluva Dynasty (1505-1570 CE):**

- Under rulers like **Krishnadevaraya**, this dynasty saw the empire reach its zenith in terms of territorial expansion, cultural achievements, and economic prosperity.
- Krishnadevaraya is particularly noted for his patronage of literature and arts.

● **Krishnadeva Raya (Important Ruler During Vijayanagara Empire)**

- Babur in his autobiography Baburnama described Krishnadeva Raya as the most powerful ruler of India.
- During the reign of Krishnadeva Raya, the Portuguese traveller **Domingo Paes came to Vijayanagar**
- The court of **Krishnadeva Raya** had eight best poets of **Telugu** literature, who were called Ashta-diggaj
- His reign has been called the '**classic era**' of Telugu literature.
- He is also known as **Andhra Bhoja**.
- He had a cordial relationship with the Portuguese.



- He authored “**Amuktamalyada**”(Telguwork on polity) and “**JambavatiKalyanam**”(Sanskrit)

● **Battle of Talikota (1565 CE)**

- The Battle of Talikota, fought in January 1565, was a pivotal conflict

● Tuluva Dynasty Year Wise Rulers	
Tuluva Narasa Nayaka	1491-1503
Vira Narasimha Raya	1503-1509
Krishna Deva Raya	1509-1529
Achyuta Deva Raya	1529-1542
Venkata I	1542
Sadasiva Raya	1542

between the Vijayanagara Empire and a coalition of Deccan Sultanates, including the Bahmani Sultanate and its successor states (Bijapur, Golconda, Ahmadnagar, and Bidar).

- The battle was a significant turning point in the history of South India.
- The growing power of the Vijayanagara Empire, under Krishnadevaraya, posed a threat to the Deccan Sultanates.



Tensions escalated due to territorial disputes, trade competition, and religious differences, with the Sultanates aiming to curtail Vijayanagara's influence.

- The battle resulted in a decisive defeat for the Vijayanagara forces. The Sultanate coalition, led by **Sultan Ali Adil Shah of Bijapur** and other rulers, overwhelmed the Vijayanagara army due to superior numbers and strategic advantage.
- The defeat at Talikota marked the beginning of the decline of the Vijayanagara Empire. **The city of Hampi** was subsequently looted, leading to widespread destruction. This loss significantly weakened the empire, leading to fragmentation and the rise of regional powers.
- **Aravidu Dynasty (1570-1646 CE):**
 - This was the last ruling dynasty of the empire, facing challenges from neighbouring kingdoms and internal strife.
 - The decline began during this period, particularly after the defeat in the Battle of Talikota in 1565.

Aravidu Year Wise Rulers	Year
Aliya Rama Raya	1542-1565
Tirumala Deva Raya	1565-1572
Sriranga I	1572-1586
Venkata II	1586-1614
Sriranga II	1614

Rama Deva Raya	1617–1632
Venkata III	1632–1642
Sriranga III	1642–1646

● Political, Social, and Economic Life

● Political Life:

- The empire had a well-organized administrative structure with a centralized government.
- The king held supreme authority, supported by a council of ministers.
- The bureaucracy was efficient, and local administration was managed through various levels of officials.

● Social Life:

- The society was diverse and included various communities, with Hinduism being the dominant religion.
- The empire was known for its religious tolerance, and different faiths coexisted peacefully.
- Festivals and public ceremonies played a vital role in social life.

● Economic Life:

- The Vijayanagara Empire had a thriving economy based on agriculture, trade, and commerce.
- Agricultural advancements and irrigation projects boosted productivity.
- Trade routes connected the empire to other regions, facilitating the exchange of goods such as spices, textiles, and precious metals.

- **Administrative Divisions**

The empire was divided into various administrative units to manage governance effectively:

- **Mandalas:** These were large administrative divisions or regions.
- **Nadus:** These are Smaller than mandalas, nadus were further subdivisions for local governance.
- **Sthalas:** These were village-level units, acting as the smallest administrative units.
- **Gramas:** These referred to individual villages within the sthalas.

This hierarchical structure allowed for efficient governance and resource management.

- **Art and Architecture**

The Vijayanagara Empire is renowned for its remarkable contributions to art and architecture:



(Virupaksha Temple in Hampi)

- **Architecture:**

- The empire is famous for its distinctive Dravidian architecture, exemplified in temples like the Virupaksha Temple in Hampi and the Vittala Temple, which is known for its musical pillars and stone chariot.

- **Art Forms:** The cultural renaissance during this period led to the flourishing of various art forms, including:

- **Carnatic Music:**

- A classical music tradition that evolved during this time, characterized by its unique ragas and talas.



- **Kuchipudi**

- A classical dance form originating from the region, known for its expressive storytelling and elaborate movements.

- **Yakshaganam:**

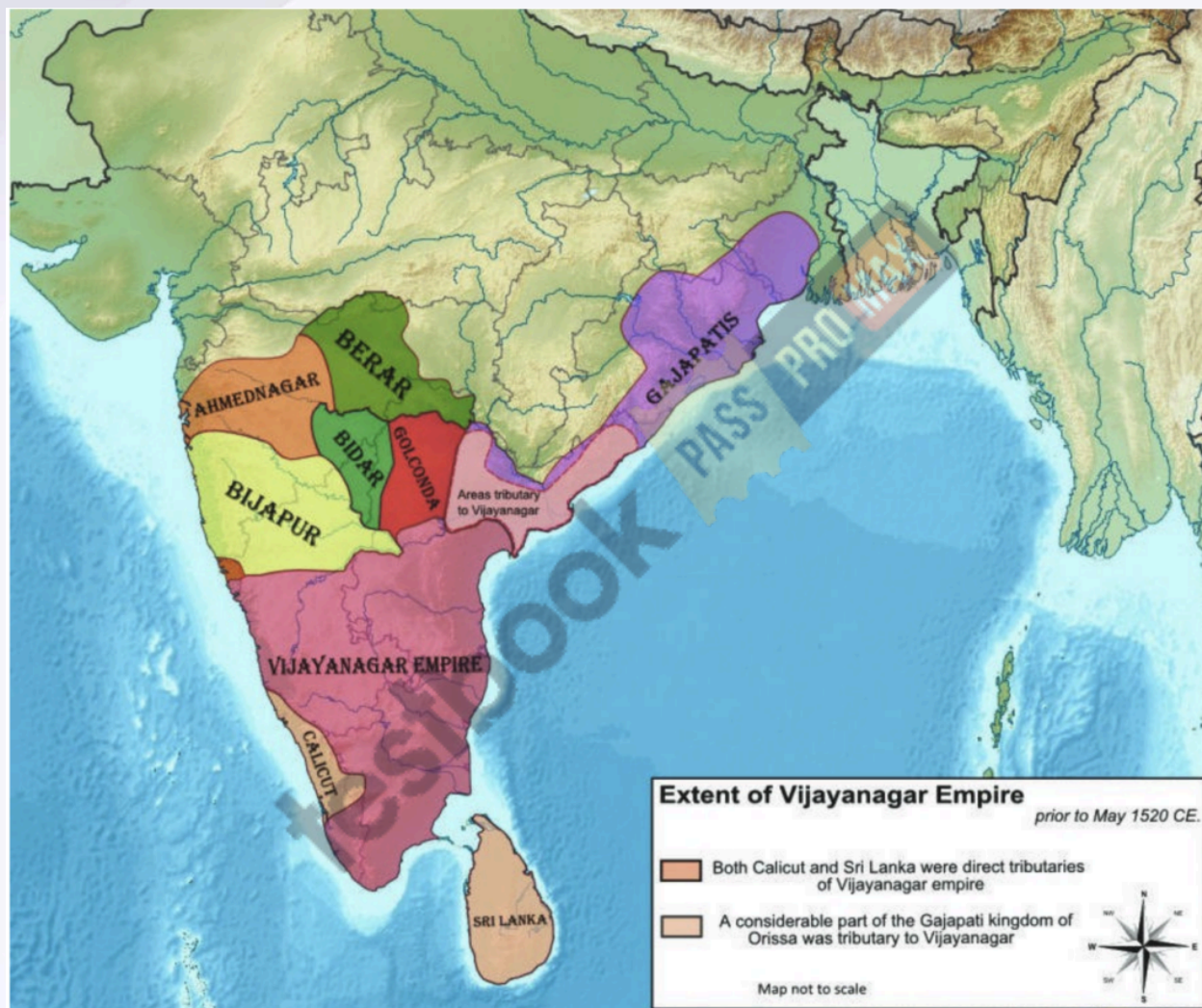
- A traditional theatre form that combines dance, drama, and music, often depicting mythological stories.



- **Contemporary Kingdoms**

- During the decline of the Vijayanagara Empire, several contemporary kingdoms emerged, significantly impacting regional politics:

- **Bahamani Kingdom:**



- Located to the northwest of the Vijayanagara Empire, it was a prominent Muslim kingdom that emerged in the Deccan plateau and was a significant rival of Vijayanagara.
- The Bahmani Kingdom was founded in **1347 CE** by **Ala-ud-Din Bahman Shah**.

- He declared independence from the Delhi Sultanate after the weakening of its control over the Deccan region.
- This move marked the beginning of a new political entity that aimed to establish its own identity in South India.
- The kingdom's first capital was **Gulbarga**, which served as the administrative and cultural center for the early years of the Sultanate
- Later, the capital was moved to **Bidar** due to its strategic location.
- At its height, the **Bahmani Kingdom** encompassed significant parts of the Deccan Plateau, covering regions of **modern-day Karnataka, Maharashtra, Telangana, and Andhra Pradesh**.
- **Reddy Kingdom:**
 - Situated in the **Royalaseema** region, it was another contemporary power that coexisted and sometimes clashed with the Vijayanagara Empire.
- **Literature:**
 - Sanskrit, Kannada, and Telugu languages witnessed voluminous literature in the Vijayanagar period.
 - Few Sanskrit works are.
 - Gangadevi wrote- Madhuravijayam
 - Krishnadevaraya wrote -ushaparinayan, jambavantikalyanam, madalasacharita.
 - Guru vidyaranya wrote—Raja kalanirnaya
- **Foreign accounts**
- **Marco Polo (1292-1295 CE):**
 - Although Marco Polo did not visit the Vijayanagara Empire directly, he described the wealth and prosperity of South India.
 - His accounts highlighted the extensive trade in spices and textiles, emphasizing the region's significance in international commerce.



- **Niccolò de' Conti (1414-1439 CE):**

- An Italian explorer, Niccolò de' Conti visited various parts of India, including the Vijayanagara Empire.
- He noted the grandeur of the cities, the hospitality of the rulers, and the richness of the land.
- His observations contributed to a broader understanding of the empire's cultural and economic vitality.

- **Abdur Razzaq (1443-1444 CE):**

- A Persian ambassador, Abdur Razzaq traveled to the Vijayanagara Empire and provided detailed accounts of Hampi's magnificence.
- He described the architectural marvels, the opulence of the royal court, and the wealth displayed by the rulers.
- His writings are considered one of the most valuable records of the empire.

- **Afonso de Albuquerque (1510 CE):**

- A Portuguese general, Albuquerque recognized the strategic significance of the Vijayanagara Empire, particularly its role in trade routes.
- He praised its military strength and emphasized the empire's importance in regional politics.

- **Domingo Paes (1520-1522 CE):**

- This Portuguese traveller offered vivid descriptions of Hampi, detailing its wealth and the lavish lifestyle of its people.
- He highlighted the flourishing arts, culture, and daily life in the capital, contributing to an understanding of the empire's societal dynamics.

- **Fernao Nunes (1530-1535 CE):**

- A Portuguese historian, Nunes wrote about the efficient administration of the Vijayanagara Empire, its military capabilities, and the cultural diversity of its populace.
- His observations underscored the empire's stability and organization during its height.

- **William Methwold (1630 CE):**

- An English merchant, Methwold noted the decline of the empire following the Battle of Talikota.
- His accounts reflected on the remnants of Vijayanagara's former glory, providing insights into the changes that had occurred in the region.

testbook 